been a little more northerly and had it broken up a few minutes earlier, it could have rained rocket debris down on Sapporo, Japan's fifth-largest city, with a population of two million.

Like many North Korean rocket tests, this one ended in structural failure, a reminder that, despite its boasts, Pyongyang has not yet perfected its missile technology. While that may give temporary solace to those worrying about North Korea's nuclear capability, it serves as a warning about perhaps the most serious threat posed by Kim Jong-un's nuclear and ballistic missile arsenal: its safety.

The images of the unprecedented June 2018 Singapore summit between Donald Trump and Kim raised hopes that a new era was dawning between Washington and Pyongyang. Yet subsequent meetings of the two leaders in Hanoi and at the Demilitarized Zone along the border between the two Koreas revealed just how difficult it remains to achieve North Korean denuclearization. As negotiations inch along, as they have for more than a quarter century, Pyongyang continues to control and add to a nuclear arsenal of unknown size and effectiveness. Yet given how little is known about Kim's nuclear and ballistic missile capability, perhaps the world should worry less about the threat of a North Korean–instigated nuclear war and more about the risk of a nuclear accident. The most frightening question raised by Kim Jong-un's pursuit of the ultimate weapon is also the simplest: Can he control his nukes?

II.

It is the ultimate status symbol, the guarantor of national survival and the ability to inflict unimaginable destruction on an enemy. Since the first atomic fireball lit up the predawn New Mexico desert in 1945, only a handful of nations have even attempted to become nuclear powers. Once they did so, all took seriously the awesome responsibility of managing their nuclear arsenals. Now a new member is joining the club, one whose track record of recklessness, aggression, and inscrutability